Participant Guidebook_IBM Z Datathon Challenge

There is no ONE problem statement. As a team, you are tasked with choosing a problem using any one of the themes below-

- Real-time AI for critical decisions
- AI secured: Innovation without exposure

Wildcard: In case you identify an important or overlooked problem but the idea may fall outside the two themes, we encourage you to use AI in a new, unexpected, or technically ambitious way to solve it, and make a wildcard entry into the competition

You must leverage IBM Z (LinuxONE) platform to solve problems you see around you and in your lives! How will you use data and ML to create a better world?

For example, a 2025 winning team addressed the critical social problem of inadequate personal safety in urban navigation by developing the Urban Route Safety Index (URSI) - a data-driven model that classifies roads as Safe, Moderate, or Risky based on real infrastructure and crime data. This enabled navigation systems to prioritize the safest routes instead of the fastest, empowering users- especially women and vulnerable commuters- to travel with confidence.

👉 Please login using discord link to interact with participants and know the latest updates:
https://discord.gg/vVUwEJh3fH
https://discord.gg/vVUwEJh3fH

IBM Z Datathon 2026 event details

Date	Event / Session	What You'll Learn / Experience	Resource/Format
July 31st, 2026	**IBM Z Datathon Orientation**	Understand the Datathon, challenge themes, participation journey, project expectations and how to get started.	Session Recording
August 7, 2026	**Team Formation & Project Ideation**	Find teammates, explore problem areas, develop project ideas and learn how to turn a real-world problem into a strong Datathon concept.	Live Helpdesk Session

August 14, 2026	**IBM Z & LinuxONE 101 / Career Opportunities with IBM Z & LinuxONE**	Explore IBM Z and LinuxONE, real-world use cases, IBM Z Xplore, career opportunities, certifications and learning pathways.	Session Recording
August 21, 2026	**AI on IBM Z**	Explore AI capabilities on IBM Z, sample projects and demos, tools and datasets, Transactional AI and potential ideas for Datathon projects.	Session Recording
August 28, 2026	**Trust & Identity – Theme Deep Dive**	Explore Trust & Identity concepts, potential use cases, projects, datasets and resources relevant to the Datathon theme.	Session Recording
September 18, 2026	**How to Win Datathon Workshop**	Continue learning through expert-led sessions, technical guidance, resources and preparation activities leading up to the Datathon.	https://us06web.zoom.us/j/81720407530?pwd=Ka52mxlvW67YnmWcmzxdxVbIswrkkZ.1
October 16, 2026	**LinuxONE Setup & Tech Prep Session**	Finalise your team, project direction and technical setup and get ready for the 24-hour competition.	https://us06web.zoom.us/j/85968654332?pwd=Cm3qD5KVUqkX1SSHuGMo1GvrZQYozF.1
October 17, 2026	**IBM Z Datathon 2026 Kick-off**	Build, test and present your solution to a real-world problem using IBM Z / LinuxONE and relevant technologies.	https://us06web.zoom.us/j/83697478897?pwd=hZldYTWMkX9PEYXdjnbYHHbzZ4Xlnf.1
October 28, 2026	**Winner Announcements & Recognition**	Celebrate winning teams and recognise outstanding innovation and participation.	https://us06web.zoom.us/j/87566913246?pwd=IxPKOnxX5Bd6ncxKidwiadqAWb9pqG.1

November 18, 2026	**IBM Z Day**	Continue your learning journey, connect with the wider IBM Z community and explore further opportunities.	http://ibm.biz/ibmzday-2026

👉 **PLEASE REFER TO THE OFFICIAL RULES & PRIZE GUIDELINES FOR MORE DETAILS**

Important Links (TBD):

- LinuxONE Community Cloud Homepage
- Registration in LinuxONE Community Cloud:
- Event code (put in project description):
- Registered user server dashboard:
- Instructions:
- Accessing VM with Jupyter Lab ML:
- Jupyter Lab token:
- LinuxONE Fast Start Guides:

Get Your LinuxONE Ready: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=y9rZwSq8pw8

Datathon Guidelines **(FOR THE FINAL SUBMISSION ON OCTOBER 17 - 18)**

- **Submission link: https://hack2skill.com/event/datathon-2026**
- Don't know how to submit your project? → Please refer to the video (**https://youtu.be/3_L3T__zEco?si=Q-ckiVTP6ByvgZEv**)
- Required submissions:
  - No more than 3 min video that covers: the problem statement, data to support the problem, your solution, and most importantly how your solution leverages IBM Z (share your tech stack, show your LinuxONE instance and model)
  - Your Code (Github link, zip upload, whatever works)
- *Optional* submissions:
  - Flowchart of your design
  - Prototype (if available)
- Important Pointers :
  - The project title must contain Team Name. Example : [Team Name_IBM Z Datathon 2026 Project]
  - Video demo of max 3 mins is compulsory
  - Don't forget to add Github/Gitlab repo link

For any issues you may face while participating please use the the Issue Form give here and our team will reach out to you to resolve the issue within 48 hours - Issue Form

Rules

1. No continuation hacks are allowed; all projects must be started within the hacking time period
2. All participants must be college students.
3. SSF has the right to expel members/teams in violation of the rules/code of conduct.
4. Taking or using any other code, projects, ideas, etc. from either participant in the hackathon or outside of it is not allowed. The project must be original and created by the participant only.
5. Use of open-source libraries, frameworks are allowed but links to those resources must be added in the submission
6. While a hackathon is a competition, only friendly competition is allowed. Harassing, poor sports talk, or competitive talk (ex. “I will crush you”) is NOT ALLOWED.
7. No projects should be created that spreads hate or bashes any social group. Avoid building projects with political inclinations.

Code of Conduct

As a participant, you give your permission for and grant SSF the irrevocable right to
Interview you in the program and appearance on videotape, audiotape, film, photograph, or any other media, whether now known or hereafter existing (recording)

- Use, reproduce, distribute, publicly display and/or publicly perform, either electronically or by any other media whether now known or hereafter existing and to allow others to do the same, your name, likeness or voice, the recordings, in whole or in part worldwide, without restrictions or limitations, in perpetuity, for any purpose, including without limitations, promotions, educational or commercial use.
- Provide to sponsors any LinkedIn, Github, or resume that you have submitted on your application
- Use your information for the purpose of user feedback, improvement of products, and sharing to sponsors.
- The 2026 IBM Z Datathon is dedicated to creating a safe and welcoming community for all students. Any harassment based on (but not limited to) race, nationality, religion, age, disability, physical appearance, body size, gender identity, gender, sexual orientation, or computing experience will not be tolerated.
- If you witness any incident that violates our code of conduct as outlined on this document please report it to any SSF organizer. We will make every effort to ensure our attendees’ safety including intervention.

Here are some additional project ideas (not mandatory, just some brainstorming help)

Theme 1: Real-Time AI for Critical Decisions

1. **Fraud Detection** – how can real-time AI and transactional data be used to detect suspicious transactions before they result in financial loss?
2. **Healthcare Prioritisation** – how can real-time AI be used to surface time-sensitive healthcare information and support faster prioritisation of patients or cases?
3. **Insurance Risk** – how can AI analyse incoming insurance claims in real time to identify potentially high-risk or unusual claims earlier?
4. **Supply Chain** – how can real-time data and AI be used to detect changing supply-chain conditions and recommend timely action?
5. **System Anomaly Detection** – how can AI be used to identify abnormal system activity as it happens and alert organisations before it causes a major disruption?

Theme 2: AI Secured – Innovation Without Exposure

1. **Sensitive Data Protection** – how can AI be used to protect personal, financial or other sensitive data while still enabling organisations to gain useful insights from it?
2. **Cybersecurity** – how can AI be used to identify unusual activity that could signal a cyberattack or security threat?
3. **Identity & Access** – how can technology be used to ensure that users access only the information they are authorised to see while identifying potentially suspicious access?
4. **Secure AI** – how can an AI assistant provide useful insights while protecting sensitive information, identities and underlying systems from unnecessary exposure?
5. **Quantum-Safe Security** – how can technology be used to identify cryptographic vulnerabilities and help organisations prepare critical systems and data for future quantum-era security risks?

Theme 3: Wildcard – Beyond the Obvious

1. **Accessibility & Inclusion** – how can AI and data be used to make information, services or opportunities more accessible to people with disabilities or underserved communities?
2. **Education** – how can AI and data be used to identify learning challenges, personalise educational support or improve access to learning opportunities?
3. **Sustainability** – how can AI and data be used to identify environmental challenges, monitor conditions or support more sustainable decisions?
4. **Community Impact** – what important or overlooked problem in your community could be addressed through an innovative application of AI and data?
5. **Intelligent Automation** – how can AI, including generative or agentic AI, be used to make a complex or time-consuming process more efficient?
6. **Beyond the Obvious** – what problem that others may have overlooked could be addressed through a novel combination of AI, data and emerging technology?

You can see sample past projects here: 2025 Project Submissions

Judging Evaluation Criteria and Standardized Scoring Rubric

Shooting Stars Foundation will organize the IBM Z Datathon judging panels composed primarily of subject matter experts and management leaders from IBM, govern the standardized evaluation criteria with IBM, and manage the end-to-end judging process.

The judging evaluation categories and criteria are detailed below along with the standardized judge scoring rubric that is used for all global judging for the IBM Z Datathon 2026.

IBM Z Datathon 2026 Judging Evaluation Criteria

What Your Project Will Be Evaluated On:

1. Value to the Community & Datathon Theme Alignment

Judges will evaluate how effectively your project solution addresses a meaningful community or societal need, and how well it aligns with the current annual Datathon theme that the team selected. Consider:

- What real-world problem are you solving?
- Who benefits from your solution?
- How clearly is the event theme reflected in your idea and execution?

0–3 Points (Developing)	4–6 Points (Proficient)	7–8 Points (Advanced)	9–10 Points (Exceptional)
Little connection to the theme, and/or no clear community or societal need or value.	Addresses a community or society need using AI for Good, but theme alignment is minimal and value / benefit is unclear or minimal	Uses AI for Good and addresses a real-world problem with clear benefits, value and strong theme alignment.	Impactful solution to a critical need in the community or society using Tech for Good; seamless theme integration.

2. Novelty & Idea Originality

This category evaluates the creativity, originality, and uniqueness of your solution concept. Projects should:

- Present new, original ideas
- Be built entirely during the Datathon
- Feature code created from scratch only during the Datathon event timeframe

0–3 Points (Developing)	4–6 Points (Proficient)	7–8 Points (Advanced)	9–10 Points (Exceptional)

Unoriginal concept; heavy use of pre-existing solution concepts and elements that are commonly available.	Shows creative effort but relies on common or predictable ideas.	Unique solution concept and innovative.	Highly innovative; reflects high originality and compelling creativity or is a breakthrough in concept. Shows strong end-to-end solution components.

3. Technical Design & Use of Mainframe/LinuxONE Community Cloud platform and AI /ML related open-source packages/code

Judges will review how effectively your solution leverages the Mainframe/LinuxONE Community Cloud platform and use of AI/ML related open-source packages/code. This includes:

- Strength of your technical architecture
- Use of AI/ML running on the Mainframe / LinuxONE (LinuxONE Community Cloud) platform. Two AI/ML labs will be provided and are available to participants as examples. The completion of both of the provided labs are mandatory prerequisites prior to teams building their own solution:
    1. Predictive AI Hybrid AI scenarios (multi-model)
    2. Predictive AI + Generative AI
- Utilization of platform capabilities such as containerization, security, scalability, and compute resources using screenshots as evidence

0–3 Points (Developing)	4–6 Points (Proficient)	7–8 Points (Advanced)	9–10 Points (Exceptional)
Minimal or no use of LinuxONE Community Cloud platform capabilities.	Basic architecture; uses LinuxONE Community Cloud platform but lacks solid use of AI/ML related open-source code/packages on LinuxONE.	Strong architecture; solid use of LinuxONE Community Cloud platform and clear use of AI/ML related open-source code/packages on LinuxONE.	Advanced architecture; optimizes LinuxONE Community Cloud platform features with exceptional exploitation of AI/ML capabilities on LinuxONE and open-source code/packages; fully exploits security and/or compute.

4. Execution & Delivery of Project Solution / Pitch Quality
Judges will look at the clarity, completeness, professionalism and solution pitch quality of your final team project video submission. This includes:

- Quality and effectiveness of your presentation
- Clarity of communication
- Compelling team pitch of your solution
- Solution demo included
- Overall team execution and delivery
- Remaining within the published time limit for video presentation submission

0–3 Points (Developing)	4–6 Points (Proficient)	7–8 Points (Advanced)	9–10 Points (Exceptional)
Incomplete, not compelling and/or lacks clear communication.	Functional, but demonstration or communication is unpolished or does not present a compelling solution pitch.	Clear, professional submission that demonstrates good solution value and functionality, a solid solution demo, and a strong solution pitch.	Clearly demonstrates high-impact solution value and functionality, a highly professional and well-orchestrated team presentation and delivery with an excellent solution pitch, and a compelling solution demo.

Additional Judging Rubric for AI Innovation Excellence Awards for All Regions

The IBM Z Datathon's "AI Innovation Excellence Awards" involve an additional, more advanced judging rubric. Teams determined by the judging panels as eligible for consideration for the AI Innovation Excellence Awards have demonstrated:

- High overall scores on the Scoring Rubric for Datathon in Section 7.2 with special emphasis on high scores in the criteria dimensions of "Novelty & Idea Originality" and "Technical Design & Use of LinuxONE Community Cloud platform and AI/ML related open-source packages/code" exploitation.
- Highly novel and compelling project solutions with excellent use of AI innovation as recognized by the expert judge panels.

The AI Innovation Excellence awards do not necessarily go to the highest-scoring teams in each Datathon region. They are designed to recognize the project submissions that the Datathon judges believe represent the most compelling, out of the box, or unconventional combination of AI innovation, technical excellence, and high impact and/or transformative potential.

Judge Scoring Rubric for AI Innovation Excellence Awards for All Regions

1. AI Innovation & Originality

Evaluates the uniqueness of the AI solution, creativity of approach, and whether the team pushed beyond conventional implementations.

7–8 Points (Advanced)	9–10 Points (Exceptional)
Innovative AI solution with clear differentiation and unique creative problem solving.	Truly novel, compelling, unconventional, and/or groundbreaking use of AI that significantly distinguishes the project from other submissions and demonstrates exceptional originality and problem solving.

2. Transformational Impact & Technical Excellence

Evaluates the solution's potential for real-world adoption, scalability, measurable impact, and sophistication of the technical implementation on LinuxONE Community Cloud leveraging AI.

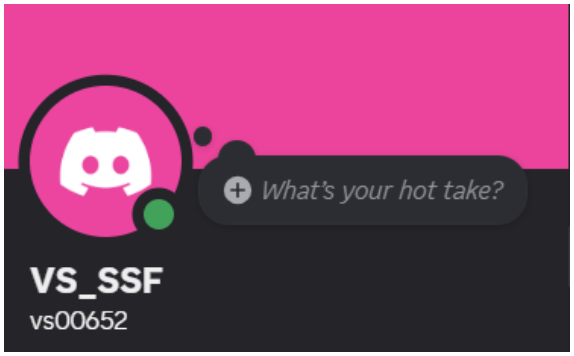
7–8 Points (Advanced)	9–10 Points (Exceptional)
Strong, advanced end-to-end technical solution with potential for high community or societal impact.	Exceptional end-to-end solution demonstrating outstanding technical sophistication, scalability, and potential to create meaningful real-world impact.

AI Innovation Excellence Award Score

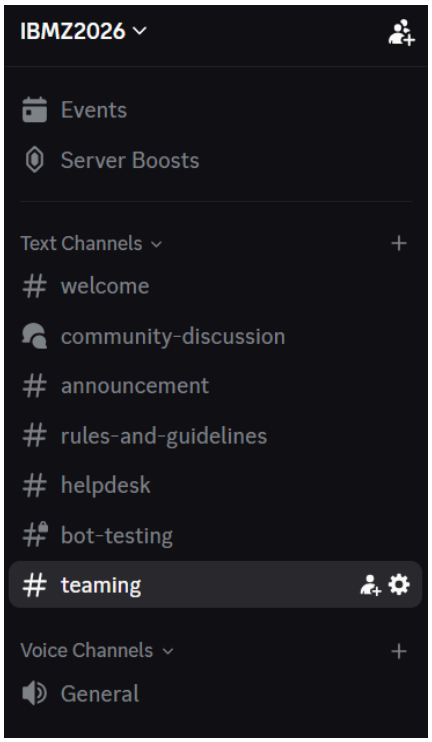
Category	Maximum Points
AI Innovation & Originality	10
Transformational Impact & Technical Excellence	10
TOTAL	20

Discord Channels

- Login using discord link: https://discord.gg/vVUwEJh3fH
- Check your user name or ID as shown below



- #announcements → Updates/reminders/links related to hackathon can be found here
- #general → Open discussion and resource sharing among participants
- #teaming → Identify team members/join team looking for members
- #help → Ask any general questions regarding the datathon
- #ibm z help → Ask IBM Subject Matter Experts questions you may have on your team's virtual machine, code, project, etc **(Only opened on the Day of Datathon)**



Schedule - Mark Your Calendars!

Come ready to learn, meet new people, win prizes, and have fun! (Dates / Time subject to change)

2026 IBM Z DATATHON EVENTS

2026 IBM Z Datathon Events – Americas

Phase	Event	Date	Americas Time
Pre-Datathon	Registration Ends	October 1	Midnight EST
	Submit Your Abstract	October 5	Midnight EST
	IBM Z Datathon – Get Your LinuxONE System Ready (Mandatory for participants)	October 16	10 AM - 11 AM EST
Datathon	Americas Hybrid Kick-off / Opening Ceremony	October 17	9:00 - 10:00 AM EST
	Day 1 In-person Datathon at NYU and UTD	October 17	9:00 AM - 05:00 PM EST
	Virtual Datathon Day 2 Continuation	October 17 - 18	Oct 17 5 PM EST – Oct 18 10:00 AM EST
	Americas Virtual Closing Ceremony	October 18	10:30 AM EST
Post-Datathon	Feedback Survey / Video	October 23	Midnight EST
	Career Panel & Winner Announcements	October 28	10 AM - 11:30 AM EST
	IBM Z Day (Winning Team Opportunity)	November 18	TBD

2026 IBM Z Datathon Events – EMEA

Phase	Event	Date	UK Time	South Africa Time
Pre-Datathon	Registration Ends	October 1	Midnight	Midnight
	Submit Your Abstract	October 5	Midnight	Midnight
	IBM Z Datathon – Get Your LinuxONE System Ready (Mandatory)	October 16	3:00 – 4:00 PM Local Time	4:00 – 5:00 PM Local Time
Datathon	Regional Hybrid Kick-off / Opening Ceremony	October 17	9:00 - 10:00 AM Local Time	9:00 - 10:00 AM Local Time
	Day 1 In-person Datathon at UWC	October 17	9:00 AM - 05:00 PM Local Time	9:00 AM - 05:00 PM Local Time
	Virtual Datathon Day 2 Continuation	October 17 - 18	Oct 17 5 PM – Oct 18 10:00 AM Local Time	Oct 17 5 PM – Oct 18 10:00 AM Local Time
	Regional Virtual Closing Ceremony	October 18	10:30 AM Local Time	10:30 AM Local Time
Post-Datathon	Feedback Survey / Video	October 23	Midnight	Midnight
	Career Panel & Winner Announcements	October 28	3:00 – 4:30 PM Local Time	4:00 – 5:30 PM Local Time
	IBM Z Day (Winning Team Opportunity)	November 18	TBD	TBD

2026 IBM Z Datathon Events – APAC

Phase	Event	Date	Australia (AEDT)	Malaysia (MYT)	India (IST)
Pre-Datathon	Registration Ends	October 1	Midnight	Midnight	Midnight
	Submit Your Abstract	October 5	Midnight	Midnight	Midnight
	IBM Z Datathon – Get Your LinuxONE System Ready (Mandatory)	October 17	2:00 – 3:00 AM Local Time	10:00 – 11:00 PM Local Time	7:30 – 8:30 PM Local Time
Datathon	Regional Hybrid Kick-off / Opening Ceremony	October 17	9:00 - 10:00 AM Local Time	9:00 - 10:00 AM Local Time	9:00 - 10:00 AM Local Time
	Day 1 In-person Datathon at Fed Uni, Cyberjaya, Saveetha and GAT	October 17	9:00 AM - 05:00 PM Local Time	9:00 AM - 05:00 PM Local Time	9:00 AM - 05:00 PM Local Time
	Virtual Datathon Day 2 Continuation	October 17 - 18	Oct 17 5 PM – Oct 18 10:00 AM Local Time	Oct 17 5 PM – Oct 18 10:00 AM Local Time	Oct 17 5 PM – Oct 18 10:00 AM Local Time
	Regional Virtual Closing Ceremony	October 18	10:30 AM Local Time	10:30 AM Local Time	10:30 AM Local Time
Post-Datathon	Feedback Survey / Video	October 23	Midnight	Midnight	Midnight
	Career Panel & Winner Announcements	October 28	4 - 5:30 PM Local Time (Session 2)	2 - 3:30 PM Local Time (Session 2)	7:30 PM – 09:00 PM Local Time
	IBM Z Day (Winning Team Opportunity)	November 18	TBD	TBD	TBD

Frequently Asked Questions

Q 1. What is the IBM Z Datathon 2026?

The **IBM Z Datathon 2026** is a global, **24-hours event** organised by Shooting Stars Foundation (SSF) in partnership with IBM. It brings together college students from around the world to build innovative AI-powered solutions using **IBM Z** and **LinuxONE** infrastructure.

Participants work in teams to solve real-world challenges across three themes: Real-Time AI for Critical Decisions, AI Secured: Innovation Without Exposure, and a Wildcard category for bold and original ideas — all under the overarching "**AI for Good**" mission.

The event runs across **8 in-person university hubs** globally (2 in India, South Africa, UK, Malaysia, Australia, 2 in USA) plus a fully open virtual track, making it accessible to students everywhere.

Q 2. Who can participate in the IBM Z Datathon?

The IBM Z Datathon is open exclusively to college and university students worldwide — undergraduate and postgraduate. You do not need prior experience with IBM Z or mainframe technologies to participate.

Students from any discipline are welcome — whether you come from computer science, data science, business, design, or any other field. Diverse, cross-functional teams are highly encouraged.

The candidate should be a currently enrolled student. Students from all countries may participate in the online (virtual) track. In-person participation is tied to your college hub.

Q 3. How do I register for the Datathon?

Registration is free. Visit the official event page at starhacks.org/ibm-z-datathon-2026 and click the Register button.

You will be prompted to select your participation track — Virtual (global, open to all) or one of the 8 In-Person hubs (Bangalore, Chennai, London, Malaysia, Australia, South Africa, Dallas, or New York).

Individual registration is required first. Once registered, your team lead must “Create a Team” on the H2S platform. If you do not yet have a team, please fill “Find a Team” form on the platform and SSF will help you in forming your team.

Registration deadline: October 1, 2026 [midnight]. After this date, registrations will be placed on a waitlist.

Q 4. Do I register as an individual or as a team?

Both steps are required. Every participant must first register individually through the main registration form on starhacks.org.

The recommended team size is 4 to 6 members. Once your team is formed, the designated team lead must complete the “Create a Team” section on the Hack2skill platform.

If you do not have teammates yet, fill “Find a Team” form after individual registration on the H2S platform. SSF will help you find a team or team members

Q 5. What are the Datathon themes for 2026?

There are three challenge themes for IBM Z Datathon 2026:

1. Real-Time AI for Critical Decisions (Detect. Decide. Respond.) — Build AI systems that analyse streaming data, identify risk, and support high-stakes decisions as events unfold.

2. AI Secured: Innovation Without Exposure (Powerful AI. Protected Data.) — Create privacy-preserving AI that learns from sensitive datasets while protecting identity, trust, and compliance.

3. Wildcard: Beyond the Obvious (Your Boldest AI + Data Idea.) — Push boundaries with a novel, data-driven AI solution that is responsible, technically ambitious, and wildly innovative.

All themes fall under the overarching mission of **AI for Good**. Your solution must demonstrate why IBM Z / LinuxONE is the right platform for your idea.

Q 6. What technology and infrastructure will be provided?

Registered participants will receive access to IBM Z / LinuxONE computing infrastructure at no cost. This is a major advantage — you get to work on the same enterprise-grade platform that powers the world's most critical industries.

IBM Z Subject Matter Experts (SMEs) will be available as mentors throughout the 24-hr datathon window via the Discord helpdesk to support you with technical queries.

You must arrange your own laptop, stable internet/WiFi, and basic development tools. Open-source datasets, public APIs, and standard libraries are permitted, provided their use is legal and properly licensed.

A mandatory "**Get Your LinuxONE System Ready**" technical setup session will be held on **October 16, 2026** (the day before the Datathon). Attendance is compulsory for all participating teams.

Q 7. What is the "Get Your LinuxONE System Ready" session and is it mandatory?

Yes — this session is mandatory for all registered participants. It is scheduled for October 16, 2026, and will run across all time zones simultaneously:

The session helps you set up access credentials, test your connection to the IBM LinuxONE system, troubleshoot any environment issues, and understand the submission platform. Technical issues discovered after the Datathon starts may not be eligible for extensions, so early setup is critical.

Q 8. What does the Datathon schedule look like?

Pre-event Schedule:

- Registration Deadline - Oct 1
- Team formation Deadline - Oct 5
- Query resolution session - Aug 7 (already concluded)
- How to win Datathon - Sept 18
- Virtual engagement activities (Mini hackathons, quizzes, technical sessions through Industry experts etc) - Refer to H2S platform for all engagement activities
- Abstract Submission Deadline - Oct 5
- Mandatory LinuxONE System Readiness Session - Oct 16

Event Schedule:

- Global Opening Ceremony + Datathon Day 1 Begins - Oct 17
- Final Submissions + Global Closing Ceremony - Oct 18

Post-event schedule:

- Feedback Survey Deadline - Oct 23
- Career Panel + Winner Announcement Session - Oct 28

- IBM Z Day - Nov 18

All times are region-specific — your Hub POC and official communications will share the localised schedule for your location.

Q 9. What tasks must I complete before the Datathon begins?

Complete the following before October 17, 2026:

A. Every team member must register individually via the main registration form.

B. The team lead must Create a Team with all member details.

C. If you need a team, fill in “Find a Team”. Please note it is mandatory to participate in 4 -6 member team

D. All teams must submit an abstract (problem statement + proposed approach) by October 5, 2026.

E. Every participant must attend learning and engagement sessions led by IBM SMEs, including the "Get Your LinuxONE System Ready" mandatory session on October 16.

F. Join the official IBM Z Datathon Discord server for announcements, mentor access, and team coordination.

Q 10. What are the prizes for the IBM Z Datathon?

The IBM Z Datathon 2026 offers a total prize pool of $50,000+ USD, distributed across multiple categories:

Online Regional Champions: APAC, EMEA, and Americas tracks (1st, 2nd, 3rd place per region)

In-Person Hub Champions: Top 3 teams at each of the 8 in-person hubs (Bangalore, Chennai, London, Malaysia, Australia, South Africa, Dallas, New York)

Special Awards: Most Innovative AI Theme, Most Creative AI Solution, Highest Participation Award, Best IBM Z Advocacy

Beyond prize money, winners receive IBM Z Day feature exposure, recognition in the IBM Z online community, LinkedIn social amplification, and career-boosting visibility.

Q 11. How are winners selected?

Value to the Community & Theme Alignment: Judges assess how well the solution addresses a meaningful community or societal need, demonstrates **AI for Good**, and aligns with the selected Datathon theme.

Novelty & Idea Originality: Solutions are evaluated on the **creativity, originality and uniqueness** of the idea. Projects must be original and built by the participating team during the Datathon

Technical Design & IBM Z / LinuxONE & AI/ML Usage: Judges evaluate the technical architecture and how effectively the solution uses the **LinuxONE Community Cloud platform and AI/ML technologies**, including relevant platform capabilities such as security, scalability, containerisation and compute resources.

Execution & Delivery: Teams are evaluated on the **quality of their project presentation and pitch**, clarity of communication, completeness of the solution, professionalism, and the effectiveness of their demonstration.

Overall Evaluation: Each of the four criteria is scored on a **10-point scale**, for a maximum standard judging score of **40 points**.

AI Innovation Excellence Awards: Eligible projects may receive additional consideration for the **AI Innovation Excellence Award**, which recognises particularly compelling and unconventional AI innovation, with emphasis on **AI originality, technical excellence, transformational potential and real-world impact**.

Judging: Projects are evaluated using a **standardised judging rubric** organised by Shooting Stars Foundation in coordination with IBM, with judging panels composed primarily of IBM subject-matter experts and management leaders.

Q 12. Can we start building our solution before the Datathon begins?

You are encouraged to arrive prepared. Teams may — and should — research their problem space, explore datasets, develop their abstract, and plan their architecture before October 17.

However, the actual code and solution must be built during the official hackathon window (October 17–18, 2026). Continuation hacks — submitting a project that was substantially completed before the event — are not permitted.

Re-using prior personal projects or commercial codebases as your core submission is also disallowed. Open-source libraries, public APIs, and IBM-provided tools are fully permitted.

Q 13. What is the submission and evaluation process?

Registration: Participants must register individually on the **Hack2Skill Event Platform** during the registration period. Teams of **4–6 members** are formed, with each team eligible to submit **one project per challenge track**

Project Development: Teams must build their projects **entirely within the official Datathon hacking period**. All project code must be created from scratch during the event timeframe.

Final Project Submission: The final submission is made through the **Hack2Skill platform** and must include a **maximum 3-minute demo video**, a **GitHub/GitLab repository link**, the correctly formatted project title, and links to any open-source resources used. A solution architecture flowchart and working prototype may also be included as recommended optional materials.

Demo Video: The video should explain the **problem being addressed, supporting data, the proposed solution, and how the solution leverages IBM Z**, including the technology stack and a demonstration of the LinuxONE instance and model.

Evaluation: Submitted projects are evaluated using a standardised judging rubric covering Value to the Community & Theme Alignment, Novelty & Idea Originality, Technical Design & Use of LinuxONE Community Cloud and AI/ML, and Execution & Delivery. Each criterion carries up to 10 points, for a maximum standard score of 40 points.

AI Innovation Excellence: Eligible projects may also be considered for the AI Innovation Excellence Awards, which place additional emphasis on AI innovation and originality, transformational impact and technical excellence.

Eligibility & Compliance: Submissions must be complete and submitted within the prescribed timeframe. Projects that violate the submission requirements, originality requirements, eligibility rules or code of conduct may be disqualified.

Q 14. How does the hybrid (in-person + virtual) format work?

All the global online participants will be attending keynote speakers sessions virtually and are expected to work with them in their own workspace. Participants at the 8-hub where

we have in-person IBM Z Datathon drive, are expected to report at the respective venues and work with their team members in-person at the designated rooms

Regardless of your track (virtual or in-person), all teams compete for the same prizes and receive the same IBM Z infrastructure access.

Q 15. How do I get support and ask questions during the Datathon?

The primary support channel is the official IBM Z Datathon Discord Server. Use it to: receive timely announcements, get help with team formation, access IBM Z resources and learning materials, and reach IBM SME mentors during the live event.

For region-specific coordination, official WhatsApp groups will be active for each hub (India, Malaysia, South Africa, UK, USA, Australia).

For general queries, you can email the SSF team at stemprograms@sstarsfoundation.org. Please avoid using personal messages to individual team members for support queries — use official channels so your question can be addressed by the right person quickly.

All FAQs, the Participant Guidebook, and session links will be available on the H2S platform. Discord channel can be used for any query resolution support during the event.

For any issues you may face while participating please use the the Issue Form give here and our team will reach out to you to resolve the issue within 48 hours - Issue Form

Q 16. What badges and certifications can I earn?

All participants who meet the eligibility criteria receive a Certificate of Participation, recognising their involvement in a globally competitive IBM-powered event.

Winners and special award recipients receive Certificates of Achievement tailored to their award category.

Additionally, participants are strongly encouraged to earn IBM Open Badges through IBM Z Xplore (learn.ibm.com/z) before and during the event. These industry-recognised digital credentials validate your IBM Z and LinuxONE skills and directly enhance your professional profile on LinkedIn and in job applications.

Educators, mentors, SSF volunteers, and Campus Ambassadors also receive dedicated recognition certificates acknowledging their contributions to the event.

📚 VOCABULARY BUILDER — 5 Key Terms Every Participant Should Know

Mainframe	A class of enterprise-grade computers, like IBM Z, known for extreme reliability, massive parallel processing, and iron-clad security. Over 70% of global financial transactions run on mainframes — which is exactly why IBM Z is the platform of choice for this Datathon.
LinuxONE	IBM's enterprise Linux server built on IBM Z architecture. Designed for mission-critical workloads, it offers superior performance, security, and scalability — and is the primary computing environment provided to all Datathon participants.
Abstract Submission	A concise written summary (typically 300–500 words) of your team's proposed solution — including the problem you're solving, your approach, the dataset(s) you'll use, and why IBM Z is the right platform. Required from all teams before October 5, 2026.
AI for Good	The overarching mission of the IBM Z Datathon — using technology to create measurable positive impact for communities, society, or the environment. Your solution should centre on a problem that matters, not just a technical showcase.
Discord Server	A real-time communication platform used as the official support hub for this event. The IBM Z Datathon 2026 Discord server is where you'll find mentor help, team formation, resource sharing, and live announcements throughout the Datathon.